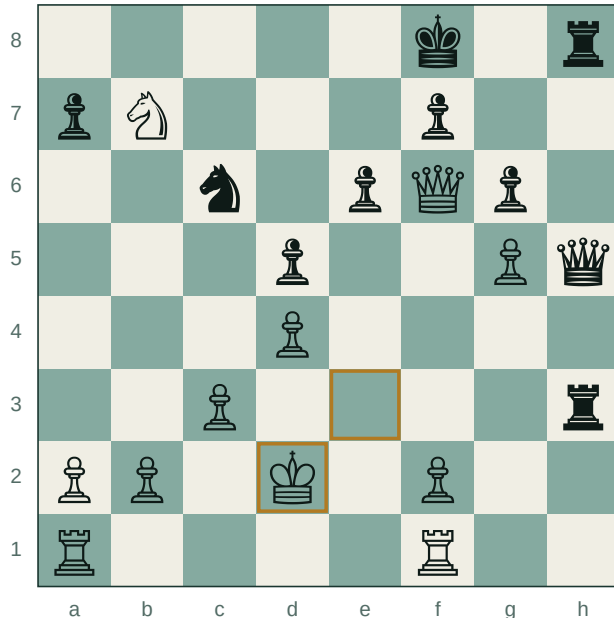


Trapping a piece: Black, move 29

Trapping a piece

Black to move



Previous move: 29.Kd2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

29...Rf3 30. Rh1 Rxf6 31. Rxh5 Rxf2+

29...Rf3 The rook moves from h3 to f3. Recorded reply: **30.Rh1**.

30...Rxf6 The rook captures the queen on f6. Recorded reply: **31.Rxh5**.

31...Rxf2+ Check restricts White to 5 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on f2.

At the end, nominal material is White 18 / Black 18 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1:** the balance goes from -1 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on d2. Geometrically undefended: knight on b7. Check for tactical protection.